FORGE

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

A Peer-Led Mentorship Program at Dooly State Prison

FORGE is a 36-week, evidence-based program that trains incarcerated men to become certified peer mentors — reducing dorm conflict, strengthening rehabilitation programming, and building a safer facility for inmates and staff alike.

What FORGE Does

FORGE prepares men to facilitate evidence-based programs, mediate conflicts, lead restorative circles, and model accountability across housing units. Mentors operate within clearly defined boundaries — they do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, or replace staff authority.

The program creates a **self-sustaining pipeline**: certified mentors from each cohort train the next, building permanent infrastructure of trained peer leaders.

How It Benefits Staff

Fewer conflicts — Mentors de-escalate before incidents occur.
Stronger programming — RISE and Pathfinders get trained facilitators.
More stable dorms — Peer accountability and a culture of restraint.
Clear boundaries — Mentors support staff authority, never undermine it.

The 36-Week Curriculum

108 sessions. 3 per week. 2 hours each. Three phases with formal gate requirements:

Phase 1: Foundation
Weeks 1–12
"Know Yourself" — CBT, emotional regulation, conflict resolution, accountability

Phase 2: Development
Weeks 13–24
"Build Others" — Facilitation, motivational interviewing, simulation training

Phase 3: Practicum
Weeks 25–36
"Lead & Serve" — Supervised mentoring, certification, 60+ field hours

Built on Evidence That Works

Curriculum drawn from **Thinking for a Change** (NIC), **Moral Reconation Therapy**, **GRIP** (California), **Seeking Safety**, and **SAMHSA's Trauma-Informed Framework**. Structure modeled on **PEP** (Texas), **RSVP** (San Francisco), **Defy Ventures**, and the **Oregon Mentors Certification Program**.

0.5%	80%	43%	$5 : $1	85%
GRIP recidivism (vs. 41.9% state avg)	Reduction in violent rearrests (RSVP)	Less likely to recidivate (RAND meta-analysis)	Return on investment (RAND Corporation)	Employment within 6 months (Defy)

What Participants Learn

Phase 1: Personal Development

- Identify and interrupt thinking errors (CBT)
- Manage emotions using the escalation curve
- 4-4-4 breathing & 5-4-3-2-1 grounding
- Assertive communication & "I" statements
- FORGE 5-step conflict resolution model
- Accountability spectrum & impact awareness
- Growth mindset & future visioning

Phase 2: Mentor Skills

- Adult learning principles & lesson planning
- Motivational interviewing (OARS framework)
- Simulation-based scenario training
- Restorative justice circles
- Crisis de-escalation protocols
- Co-facilitation practice with peer feedback
- Ethics, boundaries & confidentiality

Phase 3: Field Leadership

- Supervised co-facilitation of Phase 1 sessions
- 1-on-1 mentoring with new participants
- Independent session delivery (observed)
- Community circle facilitation
- Real-time conflict mediation
- Self-care & burnout prevention
- Review board & formal certification

Program at a Glance

216	12-15	85%	60+	6	790+
Training Hours	**Cohort Size**	**Attendance Req.**	**Field Hours**	**Competencies**	**Curriculum Pages**
108 sessions over 36 weeks	Small groups for accountability	No more than 5 absences per phase	Supervised mentoring for certification	Scored 1–4 across all assessments	Full facilitator guides & workbooks

Statistics from source programs. Full details in the FORGE Program Overview at forgementors.org

Leadership is not assigned. It is forged.

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